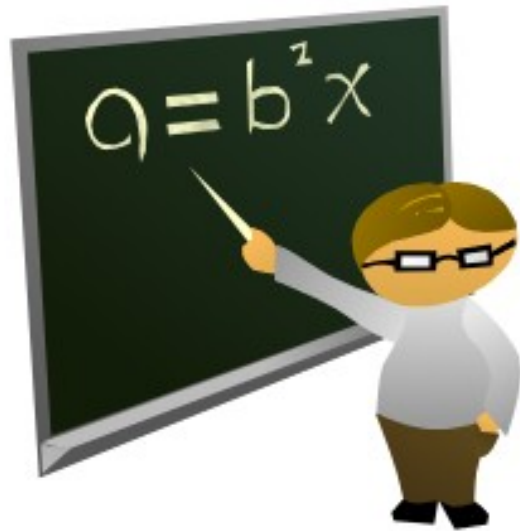


Educate Yourself



Educate Yourself

Holistic learning doesn't just apply to the classroom, but in your personal life. In fact, I've found that actively engaging in self-education improves your ability to learn in a formal setting. Picking subjects that interest you and pursuing them in your spare time can be incredibly rewarding.

However, self-education comes with its own unique challenges. Without the structure of school, it is harder to maintain a focus, find resources and test your understanding. Despite the expense and inefficiencies of taking classes, they can offer you guided instruction along with a letter grade to tell you your performance.

I've been actively engaged in self-education for as long as I can remember. I've taught myself skills like computer programming, web-design and writing. I've also learned subjects from world religions to evolutionary psychology without ever having taking a formal course. I'd like to present some of the ideas I've found useful in self-education that you might want to apply to your own life.

Most of the self-education I've done has been project-based, but there are other considerations to help improve your ability to teach yourself. Getting the right habits, overcoming the frustration barrier and setting learning goals are also helpful.

Structuring Learning Habits

A formal school structure makes forming the right habits easy. Show up to classes. Read your textbook. Take the tests. Take notes in class. All of these behaviors are not only given by the instructor, but are reinforced by the hundreds of people who surround you in classes.

Self-education is harder to form the right habits because no role-models are easily available. The structure of what you want to learn isn't handed to you on the first day. This flexibility can become a weakness if you don't have the right learning habits. Here are some habits to consider as keys to improving your learning ability:

1) Daily Reading

Reading every day is one of the best ways to improve your understanding. I strive

to read at least a book each week and 50-70 books each year. Books can't teach you everything, but they form a solid foundation of ideas you can build any learning efforts from. By reading a large volume, you can structure your education more effectively, getting a wide variety of viewpoints on a subject instead of just one.

2) Daily Practice

By working on your projects and practicing your skills every day, you can enhance any understandings given to you through reading books. Practicing helps provide a structure for your learning, since it is the first time you will have a benchmark of your abilities.

3) Daily Goal Setting

Reading and practice aren't enough if they aren't directed. If your efforts are aimed at every subject imaginable, you won't get into any useful depth into a subject. But by setting learning goals and breaking it into daily increments, your learning can be more useful to you by learning subjects fully instead of just in pieces.

How to Build Daily Habits

Building habits is another subject that warrants another book in itself. I've written [another e-book](#) for that exact purpose. Changing habits isn't that difficult, but here are a few tips to get yourself started on building the right habits to improve your self-education efforts:

1) **Set a trial to condition a habit for 30 days.** Decide to read forty pages a day for a month. Decide to practice your web-design skills for an hour every day. Decide to set daily goals for your learning over the next thirty day period. Thirty days make a habit.

2) **Be consistent.** Set your trial to do the same habit every day, in the same way. Reading one day, listening to a speaker the next and practicing a third day are too disjointed to become habits.

3) **Enjoy the habit.** If you don't enjoy it, your habit won't stick. If you brainstorm a list of ways, it isn't hard to find ways to enjoy activities like reading, practicing and goal-setting.

4) **Pick a time.** I like to do morning reading, because it gives me uninterrupted quiet hours where I can focus my thoughts on a particular subject. Picking a specific time each day will reinforce your habit.

If you aren't sure where to find the time to do daily reading or practice, ask yourself how much television you watch or web surfing you do. If you are serious about learning on your own and can't seem to find the time, TV and StumbleUpon need to be the first things to go.



Quick Tip!

Want more information about how to reprogram your habits? I've written a full five-part series on the subject, [Habitual Mastery](#). If you still want more depth you can read my full e-book on the subject, [How to Change a Habit](#).

Overcoming the Frustration Barrier

Self-education and frustration often go hand-in-hand. Without an instructor who can show you what you're doing wrong, or a guidebook to tell you the next step, self-education requires more patience than taking classes. While I've found classes usually drag at a slow pace, self-education can go too fast.

Ultimately, overcoming frustrations in self-education is a matter of motivation. If you are interested in a subject and that subject is important to you, a few speed-bumps won't keep you from continuing forward. However, I've found it useful to have a few methods to overcome the frustration barrier so self-learning can go smoothly.

Here are a few tips for reducing the frustration barrier:

- 1) **Write Down any Obstacles.** If I encounter a programming problem I don't currently know how to solve, I try to write down the problem in as much detail as

possible first. Writing obstacles out thoroughly makes it easier to think through problems.

2) **Use Forums.** There are online forums for just about any discipline, skill or subject. If you are having trouble understanding an idea, or are looking for books to explain it, online forums can be incredibly helpful. Search online for answers first, but keep forums as a tool in case you get stuck.

3) **Get How-To Manuals.** If you are trying to teach yourself a skill (doing your taxes, programming, graphic design, etc.) how-to manuals are invaluable. For a tiny fraction of the price of a full course, they can be an excellent reference if you get stuck.

4) **Attack From a New Angle.** If you hit a roadblock in your understanding, try coming at the idea from a different viewpoint. Spend time working on other concepts and come back to it after you have learned more.

Setting Learning Goals

One of the biggest challenges with self-education is that there is little structure. There are no goals, few plans and little direction. Although this loose format makes it easy to explore what you want to learn, instead of what are told you need, it also makes it harder to stick with. Without structure, it requires far more internal discipline to keep going through minor obstacles.

I've found it helpful to create learning goals to give yourself an extra push. Here are a few example goals you could set to give the learning process more structure:

- Read a certain amount of books each year.
- Work towards a project that requires learning.
- Be able to do something before a deadline. Example: *Be able to compose a song, complete your financial statements or speak in Latin before June 3.*

The idea of giving yourself forced deadlines and constraints might not sound like fun. Won't goals just suck off the spontaneity of the moment?

I've found the opposite is true. Having too much structure can be suffocating (as I'm sure many feel about formal education). But too little can make learning boring and aimless. Setting your own learning goals allows you to set the right amount of structure so you can explore new ideas, but also educate yourself in a systematic fashion.

A few tips on setting your learning goals:

1) **All Goals Need to Be Written.** A goal that isn't written down, doesn't exist. Write down your goal as a few sentences, along with a deadline.

2) **Make it Objective.** At any point along your progress, you should be able to easily decide whether you have achieved your goal. "Learning more" isn't a goal, just a whim.

3) **Set Difficult, But Achievable Deadlines.** Giving yourself deadlines forces you to take action instead of just procrastinating. If the deadlines are too easy, they won't inspire action until you are too far behind. If the deadlines are too hard, you've just created a recipe for frustration.

4) **Break it Into Daily and Weekly Actions.** Your goal should be broken into daily and weekly increments. A goal you need to complete today has more urgency than one due in a few months.

5) **Review Your Goals Regularly.** Check over your goals at least once a week to see how you're making progress.



Quick Tip!

Need help setting your goals? You can read more with my nine-part series on goal-setting [here](#).

Self-Education Summary

Self-education has enormous potential if you are willing to pursue it. Getting the right habits and creating a structure for learning can be initially difficult, but afterwards those habits can be put to use towards any goal you might have.

I've collected various resources for self-education you might find useful to get started:

[MIT OpenCourseWare](#) – A collection of free courses online offered by MIT.

[EHow.com](#) - How to articles on a variety of subjects.

[FreeEd.net](#) - “Free education on the Internet” according to their website.

[Portal to Free Online Courses](#) – This article links to many major universities which offer free courses online.

◦ Part IV ◦

Summary of Holistic Learning

Getting Started

Holistic learning isn't something you can read over once and then master. It is a combination of a strategy along with various tactics, all designed to improve the way you learn. Practicing these methods along with experimenting on your own can give you more options.

Where you take holistic learning is up to you, but if you aren't sure where to start, here are a few suggestions:

Analyze Your Strengths and Weaknesses

After reading through the holistic learning strategy, the first step should be to pinpoint where your strengths are and what you might have trouble with. Some of these weaknesses can be avoided (through picking courses that highlight your strengths), while others need to be compensated for.

You probably already have a good idea at what subjects you are skilled at (math,

history, art, science, etc.). Now you should spend time asking yourself what points in the learning strategy and types of information you have the most difficulty with.

For myself, I know that my strengths are in abstract and concrete information. I have a highly visual style of learning, which is reflected in many of my descriptions throughout this book. My strongest phase in the holistic learning sequence has always been the Explore phase, although practice has improved my ability to acquire and debug.

My weaknesses would be with arbitrary information. Learning the tools mentioned in the techniques portion of this book have helped greatly, but trying to store lists of facts, dates or definitions hasn't been my specialty. Knowing my strengths and weaknesses in learning help me highlight where I can use my strengths and learn new techniques to smooth over any flaws.

Start a Mind Challenge

The Mind Challenges are set up for the purpose of building new habits. Many of these methods are initially slower, if you aren't used to them. Taking on a challenge for the next 2-4 weeks, can build up your speed and effectiveness using them. Eventually you will need to tailor your approach to suit your goals.

Here are a few important tips to make sure that the holistic techniques stick:

1) **Commit for at least 3 weeks.** There might be several techniques you want to explore from this book. But unless you spend at least three weeks working through a Mind Challenge, you won't be able to turn the new method into a habit.

2) **One at a time.** Don't try to take on several challenges at once. Focusing on one challenge at a time, for the entire duration, will have a bigger shift.

3) **Metaphor, Visceralization, Diagramming first.** Those techniques form the core of the holistic learning system. Pick one of these for your first challenge.

4) **Use the bonus material.** Included with this book are six printouts designed to help you with the Mind Challenges. Printing these off or creating your own can give you a template to make learning the new techniques easier.

5) **Document your progress.** Keep a one-sentence journal for your Mind Challenge. This means writing 1-2 sentences about your progress with the technique. This will make it easier to commit and will also help you to troubleshoot any problems that might come up using the trial.



Setup a Better Studying Routine

Most of the focus of this book has been on mental activities to save studying time. Better studying methods using a better strategy. If your study habits are sloppy, you might be wasting hundreds of hours, even if your learning strategy is fine.

Here are a few productivity ideas you might want to consider:

1) **Do you study a little bit each day or just cram before the final?** Taking time to study every day can save you far more time in the long run than trying to study all at once. I tend to do my reading for the upcoming week on the weekend all at once. Spending just a few hours a week on the weekend saves me from all-night cram sessions later.

2) **Are your notes and textbooks organized?** While I'm a fan of the learn-it-once approach, sometimes you need to review. If all your material is scattered and unusable, this will waste time. Less mess means less stress.

3) **Are you focused during your study sessions, or plagued with distractions?** I study by myself without music, IM, cell phone messaging or any form of human contact. Putting myself into sensory deprivation keeps me focused on studying. If

Becoming more productive and efficient is another topic, which I write about frequently on my own website as well as being the subject of various books. Here are just a few resources you might want to consider if you are trying to get more done in less time:

Productivity Websites

ScottHYoung.com - My website devoted to productivity, learning and habits.

ZenHabits.net - Productivity through simplicity.

Lifehack.org - One of the largest productivity websites.

PickTheBrain.com - Productivity and motivation.

StudyHacks – Productivity for the student

StevePavlina.com – Personal development for smart people.

Productivity Books

[Getting Things Done](#) - The classic by David Allen.

[The Power of Full Engagement](#) - Energy management.

[Zen To Done](#) - A spin off of Getting Things Done, this one focuses on slowly building productive habits.

[How to Be a Straight-A Student](#) & [How to Win at College](#) – Both classic books that can help you become more productive and handle the challenges of learning. Definitely worth reading!

Decide What You Want

No technique, method or trick can replace motivation. If you don't have a reason to learn, get good grades or know your subject, the best you can do is drag yourself to class. I would never say I've loved every class I've taken. In fact, I've hated classes even after getting an A.

However, I've always been motivated by learning. New ideas and subjects fascinate me, even if the classroom format they are presented in do not. That drive to learn has made using the holistic learning strategy far easier in the long run.

Nobody can make you interested in a class you find boring. No strategy can make you learn something you don't want to. If you're only chasing a piece of paper from a prestigious University, instead of the knowledge and ideas that paper represents, then I don't think any strategy can be helpful.

Find your reason for learning. Even if the reason is as simple as curiosity, find a reason to want to know.

Recap of Major Concepts

At over 200 pages, this book has covered a lot of material. This recap of all the material can serve as a reference if you want to review any ideas or refresh your understanding.

Holistic learning is a strategy based on weaving information into webs, instead of bludgeoning yourself with rote-memorization. The foundation of this strategy is:

1) **Constructs** - The sum total of all connections that represent your knowledge about a subject. These are the cities of your mind.

2) **Models** - Compact units of information that form the seeds of constructs. These are metaphors, visceralizations and diagrams. Models are the major intersections in the roadmap of your constructs.

3) **Highways** - Connections between different constructs. These aid in creative thinking. “Thinking outside the box” perfectly describes the act of thinking beyond the current constructs you have.

Holistic learning works in a sequence of five steps. These steps aren't always followed one-by-one, but this is the path they usually take:

- 1) **Acquire** - Receiving information through your senses.
- 2) **Understand** - Get the surface of information.
- 3) **Explore** - Connect that basic idea to others. Exploration works in three main ways:
 - a) **Depth** Exploration - Exploring the background of an idea.
 - b) **Lateral** Exploration - Exploring associated ideas.
 - c) **Vertical** Exploration - Exploring the idea as it relates to different constructs.
- 4) **Debug** - Prune away false connections.
- 5) **Apply** - Take an idea and give it meaning beyond immediate uses.

Information is similar to digestion. The process is the same regardless of what you ingest. But the inputs can be very different. Taking into account different information types can help you plan your learning efforts. There are five major types of information:

- 1) **Arbitrary** - Facts, dates, lists, rules and sequences. They have little logical grouping or depth.
- 2) **Opinion** - Information gathered for the sole purpose of supporting or defeating your argument. Volume is important here, rather than being able to memorize.
- 3) **Process** - Information in the form of skills. Requires practice, but is easier to remember.

- 4) **Concrete** - Ideas that are easy to visualize. These are often practical ideas that are easy to experience.
- 5) **Abstract** - Ideas that are difficult to experience. Math, philosophy and physics are some of the most abstract fields.

Summary of Techniques

Speed Reading

- 1) Use a pointer.
- 2) Practice read.
- 3) Use active reading to improve learning while reading.

Flow-Based Note Taking

- 1) Don't write notes in a rigid hierarchy.
- 2) Create associations between briefly written ideas.

Metaphor

Look for a story, image or process that mirrors what you are studying.

Visceralization

- 1) Create a mental image of what you are studying.
- 2) Add other sensations and emotions to this image.
- 3) Look for ways the image does not apply or does not fully cover the subject to prevent errors later.

Diagramming

Create flow, concept or picture diagrams to link together several ideas onto the same source.

Link Method

- 1) Create a sequence of symbols that are easy to visualize.
- 2) Create “links” between each item by visualizing a bizarre scene that combines the two.
- 3) Create a link between the first sequence item and a trigger.

Peg Method

Same as link method except you link each idea to a list of 0-12 rhyming symbols you can recall easily.

Information Compression

Three main forms:

- 1) **Mnemonics** - Using words to compress several ideas into a single idea.
- 2) **Picture Compression** - Create a picture that links several ideas under a single theme.
- 3) **Notes Compression** - Rewrite a vast quantity of notes onto just a few pages.

Practical Usage

Look for ways to apply the idea in your daily life.

Model Debugging

Practice questions in your subject regularly and look for potential errors in your holistic web.

Project-Based Learning

Set up projects of 1-3 months that will force you to learn new concepts. This is a useful exercise for self-education, where there is less structure to guide you.

The Productive Student

1) Manage Your Energy

- Stay in shape, eat healthy and don't work without sleep.
- Schedule a day off each week.

2) Don't "Study"

3) Nuke Procrastination

- Set up a Weekly and Daily Goals list to keep focused.

4) Batch smaller tasks into groups.

5) Be organized.

- Keep a calendar, to-do list and carry a notepad with you at all times.

Self-Education

Self-education can be cheap, fast and rewarding but it also has challenges. Namely, it has less structure and is more difficult than formal education. The main ways you can improve your ability to teach yourself are:

1) Improve your habits

2) Overcome the frustration barrier

3) Set learning goals to track progress.

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Check out my other books and programs:

[How to Change a Habit](#) – This e-book explores the philosophy and methods I've used to change dozens of habits in my life from exercising regularly, reading more and becoming organized. If you want to build the right habits, this book will tell you how.

[Holistic Learning](#) – My first *free* e-book on Holistic Learning. This introduces the concepts that I later refined in the book you are reading today.

[Goals! An Interactive Guide](#) – My first free product, this program explores why you need to set goals and how to do it with a fun interactive game.